

Child Health

Good care in the first two years builds a strong, healthy child. Feed well, vaccinate on time, keep your child clean, and act early when they are sick.

For community members

Key messages

- Breastfeed as soon as possible after birth. For the first six months give only breast milk. No water, juice, herbs, cow or goat milk, or other food.
- From six months, add soft foods from many food groups: mashed egg, fish, meat, beans, orange fruits like pawpaw, and dark green leaves. Keep breastfeeding to two years or more. Avoid sugary drinks and sweet biscuits.
- Never feed a baby with a bottle. It is hard to keep clean and can cause diarrhoea. Use a clean cup and spoon.

- Take your child for all vaccines on time. They are safe, effective and free. Check the Child Health Record Book. From 6 months your child needs vitamin A every six months, and from 12 months deworming tablets.
- Take your child every month to be weighed and measured. A MUAC tape around the arm shows if a child is too thin.
- Wash your hands with soap, boil drinking water, keep babies away from smoke and sick people, and sleep under a mosquito net.
- Keep breastfeeding when your child is sick. Give extra fluids.
- Give love and attention: smile, talk, play and praise. Raise children with words and guidance, not violence.

Take your child to the health centre within 24 hours if they have

- Fast breathing, chest pulling in, or a cough for 14 days or more
- Diarrhoea with blood, diarrhoea for 14 days or more, or signs of drying out: very thirsty, dry lips, passing very little urine
- Fever for 7 days or more, or fever with fits
- Not able to drink or breastfeed, or vomiting everything
- Very sleepy, hard to wake, or fits
- Swollen feet, or very thin arms

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.